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Landscape as Seen by the Military



Siège d'Ypres, *1677. (Courtesy Bibliothèque Nationale)*

I am happy to pay my respects to the two groups whose authority and guidance I have always willingly recognized: the professional geographers of this country and the general officers of the United States Army. There was a time when I would have included officers of field grade; but when I became a major myself, I was less impressed with their collective wisdom.

These two groups have taught me what little I know about landscape reconnaissance. I was first exposed to geography under Derwent Whittlesey at Harvard many years ago; and when I was a second lieutenant in 1941, I was sent to an army intelligence school which no longer exists—the Military Intelligence Training Center at Camp Ritchie, Maryland. I believe I was the first trainee to check in at that strange institution.

I learned a good deal while I was there; and when I was at length graduated, I knew everything about the current German order of battle, the organization of the German Army from corps to platoon, the caliber of its various weapons, and how to read or decipher a German *Soldbuch,* as well as all the insignia of rank and branch of service. We also learned map reading.

All this training was presumably to teach us how to collect, evaluate, and disseminate information about the enemy and his capabilities. We did not speculate about the environment and its psychological impact nor about the relationship between the environment and man. The kind of knowledge we acquired was entirely practical and military. We learned to assume that the occupants of that environment were animated by one very clear purpose: to hold on to it as long as they could. We learned to study the environment only insofar as it might help or hinder the carrying out of that purpose. One reason it was easy to ignore the environment was that it was all too familiar. While the make-believe tactical situations were constantly changed, the terrain was always the same fragment of the Blue Ridge Mountains.

In other words, we came to think of the environment as a kind of setting or empty stage upon which certain alarming and unpredictable decisions and actions took place. Geographically speaking, I suppose military intelligence in those far-off days was a very anthropocentric discipline. But so was much geography.

After six months at Camp Ritchie, I was sent to North Africa, where I joined the G-2 section of the 9th Infantry Division; and when we had finished in Tunisia, we were sent to invade Sicily. In both places I had a chance to display my erudition about the makeup of the Hermann Goering Division, the range of the 88 on the modified Tiger tanks, and the shoulder patch of a warrant officer in the quartermaster reserves. I was mortified to see how little difference this information made, but the earlier illusion that environmental factors could be ignored persisted. Both in Africa and in Sicily, we were dealing with fast-moving units racing across a dry and relatively empty landscape. Their impact on the terrain, except for an occasional burst of artillery, was slight. The stage continued to be vacant and uninteresting except when some military action was taking place.

Normandy of course was a different matter, a much more complex and much more familiar landscape. It was when the division headquarters was billeted in a Norman chateau that I discovered a sizeable library devoted to the bocage country—something I had never heard of before, though we were in the midst of it and having trouble getting out of it. It was even possible to buy books by some of the French human geographers—Deffontaines and Vidal de La Blache and Demangeon. This was at a time when G-2 had nothing to do except prophesy the imminent collapse of the German Army.

As we know, it did not collapse in August of 1944, and the 9th Infantry Division and many other divisions passed a cold and uncomfortable winter in the Huertgen Forest. I still don't know why we stayed as long as we did; and like everyone else, I was so sure that in a day or two we would push ahead and capture Cologne and cross the Rhine that all I could think about was the landscape which lay immediately in front of us and which we were convinced we would occupy by the end of the week.

It was a desolate countryside, badly damaged by incessant artillery fire. Nevertheless, it was possible to collect out of the ruins a respectable number of guidebooks, picture postcards, tourist maps, and elementary local geography and history texts; and so for the first time, I began to learn something about a landscape. But again it was almost entirely in human terms, in military terms: How was the enemy using the terrain? how were they exploiting it? where were their installations? and how could we use it once it was ours? This meant studying that tourist literature, examining the picture postcards and textbooks in order to visualize the landscape. If the farmers raised wheat (as some of them did), would our half-tracks bog down in the naked winter fields? Were there roads in the valleys, where there was a problem of bridges, or on the hilltops, where there was a problem of visibility? And the house types had to be identified, so I thought, because I wanted to know if the barns were large enough to accommodate trucks and whether there were orchards where guns could be concealed.

I enjoyed investigating these matters, and I remember the many nights I spent interrogating the few prisoners we got in order to acquire more detailed information about those villages and countrysides and forests. I read the prisoners' diaries, written in indelible pencil under God knows what circumstances, and dutifully examined their *Soldbücher*. I asked them about specific bridges and roads, how they had arrived at their unit, and where the antiaircraft batteries were located; and I finished the questioning by telling them to indicate all these locations on a map. Actually I knew far more about the terrain than they did because most of them had come from a replacement center only a day or two before.

In the morning I always made a detailed report to the general and his chief of staff (who was a handsome, pink-cheeked young colonel from West Point by the name of Westmoreland). While I talked, the general slept, and no doubt dreamt of getting a transfer to an office job in London or Paris.

Eventually my illusion that anyone was interested in the intelligence I had collected and evaluated vanished, and I realized that whenever we *did* advance it would only be after a saturation bombing which would obliterate roads and fields and forests and house types and settlement patterns as if they had never existed. But an illusion of another sort took its place: a private image of the world, or at least of that dark and mysterious landscape ahead of us.

By day I was well aware of its ruins and destruction and of the winter misery surrounding us; but by night, when I was working on the G-2 report, I was transported into an entirely different landscape—a Classical landscape of well-defined places and well-defined inhabitants, all animated by that one collective purpose. The landscape came into being as a result of those innumerable tactical questions: Where are your headquarters? Who is your commanding officer? What is your unit and branch of service? What are the boundaries, the routes, the channels of communication? Even when this landscape trembled from an artillery barrage and burst into flames, I still saw it in my mind's eye as orderly and intelligent, with its clear-cut hierarchy of officers and men, each with his insignia of rank, each one doing a particular duty and filling out a daily report, each one moving through a spatial organization indicated by signs and boundaries. Finally the landscape ceased to be an empty impersonal stage and became part of a whole way of life, a place where men and environment were in harmony with one another and where an overall design was manifest in every detail.

What I had unwittingly reconstructed was a traditional European landscape of the eighteenth century. At the same time it was also a military landscape in every feature. Because I think that the two—at least on the Continent—were in many respects identical, just as the organization of the military and civil societies was in many respects identical. And I still find myself wondering if there is not always some deep similarity between the way war organizes space and movement and the way the contemporary society organizes them; that is, if the military landscape and military society are not both in essence intensified versions of the peacetime landscape, intensified and vitalized by one overriding purpose which, of necessity, brings about a closer relationship between man and environment and between men.

My obsession with this version of landscape was increased by a book I read that winter. It was a popular life of Frederick the Great, distributed, I suppose, by some German book-of-the-month club and found in every middle-class home in the Huertgen Forest. What impressed me was the description of Frederick as an old man, through with war, traveling about his impoverished and ruined country in a carriage, stopping to talk to villagers and farmers. "How much do you pay for bread?" "What rent do you pay?" "What crop are you planting?" Then he would write in a notebook: "Roads very bad in such and such a village; speak to Baron X" or "The mayor is lazy and dishonest; see about having him replaced." What he was collecting was intelligence of an almost Classical sort: What men *did* was what mattered, not

what they thought or felt; what the countryside provided in the way of food and shelter was what interested him, not its beauty or its barrenness.

I began to see that regimented landscape in front of us as a kind of formal eighteenth-century garden, and the eighteenth-century formal garden as the regimented militarized state in miniature.

When we finally broke out of the Huertgen Forest in February and rushed ahead to cross the Rhine, I was not entirely happy to see that imaginary landscape disintegrate. Clear-cut identities became blurred; well-established units dissolved into scattered individuals hiding in the woods; boundaries and demarcations ceased to mean anything. And the various headquarters and command posts we had so carefully marked on the acetate overlay proved to be nothing more than heaps of rainsoaked ruins littered with mimeographed orders that no one had bothered to obey or even to read.

The end of the war saw the end of this particular illusion. But I think the experience in the Huertgen Forest taught me something which has no geographical or military value but which has helped me see and enjoy the world: *Every landscape of any size or age has a style of its own, a period style such as we discern or try to discern in music or architecture or painting, and a landscape true to its style, containing enough of the diagnostic traits, whether it is in Appalachia or Southern California, can give an almost esthetic satisfaction.* By accepting this admittedly superficial approach, we can, I think, learn to define other unknown landscapes, provided we know the necessary traits.

I am thinking in particular of the American landscape which has come into existence since my time in the army, almost a half century ago. I cannot truthfully say that my own efforts to understand and appreciate the period qualities of Flatbush or Las Vegas have been very successful. This well may be a matter of age. But it may also be a matter of perspective—whether we see it from the ground or from the air. And this is where I think new intelligence techniques will eventually teach us how to define landscapes, just as they have in the past.

I suspect that the time is not far off, if indeed it has not already arrived, when we will refer to World War II as the last of the classic wars. And one good reason for so doing would be this matter of military intelligence techniques: the manner in which we perceive and evaluate environmental factors. In World War II, G-2 was still almost totally dependent on the ordinance map for its information about the terrain. The vertical aerial photograph was of course widely used; but it was in a sense a photographic transcription of the human eye—more accurate, much more detailed, but still a kind of instant map. It was about thirty years ago that aerial or space photography evolved its own perspective, its own vision. The accomplishments of this new photography are quite beyond my understanding. However, I realize, like everyone else, that it has not only revealed the world to us from a remote point in space but has revealed aspects of the world that entirely transcend the

human visual experience; remote sensing and hyperaltitude photography present an image we can only begin to understand after exhaustive interpretation.

But this is no doubt already an accepted preliminary to the acquisition of information—we have to learn to read instead of merely learning to see. And once we have learned to read the new photography, we will discover a new environment and a new relationship between that environment and man and, I dare say, discover a new definition of man. That is what many geographers are trying to do, though again the new techniques in the discipline entirely escape me.

What we do with this insight from outer space remains to be seen. I like to think that in the future some young intelligence officer, puzzling over all this airborne information and trying to evaluate it and disseminate it according to the book, will suddenly glimpse within it a new landscape of harmony and order for the world to aspire to. But for *his* sake, and for the sake of all of us, let us hope that the moment of wartime revelation lies far in the future.



A Vision of
New Fields



Irrigated fields, southwest U.S. (From Georg Gerster, Flights of Discovery, *London, 1978)*

The best place to find new landscapes is in the West. Pictures painted on canvas is not what I mean, nor glimpses of pleasant rural scenery, but landscapes as we are now learning to see them: large-scale organizations of man-made spaces, usually in the open country.

Spaces of this sort are common everywhere, but it is in the West that they have been given unusual forms and dimensions: compositions of fields hard to interpret when seen at eye-level as we pass through them, but clear and sharply defined when seen from the air; and it is when we fly over it that we begin to understand the American landscape from a new perspective.

I am thinking in particular of the mosaics of irrigated land we so often fly over when traveling from East to West. They are of two kinds: those we see in Nevada and Utah and Arizona stand out in vivid contrast to their pale and empty background of desert, whereas those we see when we are above parts of eastern Washington or west Texas or Colorado or Nebraska have a far less dramatic setting; they seem gradually to emerge out of the rolling prairie. To me these latter irrigated landscapes are the ones especially worth our attention.

Irrigation is of course no novelty in the West. Many irrigated landscapes have flourished here for more than a century, and some, like those in the San Joaquin and Imperial valleys, are rich and vast. Only within the last generation, however, have we been able to see them at a glance from several thousand feet in the air and to perceive them as units; for the first time we were aware of their brilliant variety of color and texture and shape. We fell into the lazy habit of comparing these landscapes to some familiar pattern: to a tapestry or a floor covering or to the work of some painter: Mondrian or Fernand Léger or Diebenkorn. We did not think about what lay beneath the surface; that was not part of the composition as we saw it, and if we speculated about the origin of these landscapes and their ultimate meaning, it was to note the obvious: the miracle of water diverted from a lake or impounded river radically transforming the desert. We saw the enormous dams, the network of ditches, and pondered the organization of men and machines that had produced this miracle. But by then we had left the landscape far behind.

We traveled too fast, and still travel too fast for fresh thinking about what we see below. But flying over that other kind of High Plains irrigated landscape proves to be a different experience. It is so huge and yet so simple in composition that we can study it as we look down, perceive it in other than painterly terms. We no longer see the surface as concealing what is beneath it, but as explaining it.

Only about three decades ago did this new kind of irrigated landscape begin to evolve, and not in the desert but in the rangeland of the High Plains—a region somewhat removed from the main routes of transcontinental air travel, which is perhaps why it has long remained unnoticed. Its most conspicuous feature is the great number of perfectly circular green fields.

Almost completely devoid of familiar human installations—houses and roads and towns and groves of trees—this landscape is hard for the eye to measure, but each of these round fields contains 130 acres and is enclosed in a square each of whose sides is a quarter mile long. In parts of the High Plains these round fields seem to stretch without interruption in uniform rows almost to the horizon. Interspersed among them are many large fields which are severely rectangular, some of them long and narrow, others square. No details, natural or man-made, interrupt the expanse of simple geometrical forms. The few roads and highways conform to the overall grid pattern. There is a predominance of shades of green. The landscape is one of extraordinary simplicity and enormous size, but because of its monotony it is best experienced briefly and from the air.

The High Plains is an open, undulating region east of the Rockies, extending from the Canadian border down into west Texas. Sparsely inhabited and with few towns and an inconspicuous scattering of farms and ranches, it once was largely devoted to the raising of wheat and cattle, and it is still a sunlit countryside of cloudless skies and of waving wheat and prairie grass. Rainfall is barely sufficient for farming, and there are few streams for irrigation. But beneath the surface there is a large supply of water, and thanks to new engineering and agricultural techniques and the former availability of cheap energy, this supply has been tapped and brought to the surface for irrigation, and these round fields are the result. There are more than 10,000 of them in western Nebraska, and in west Texas and parts of Colorado and Kansas, even more.

What distinguishes this new irrigated landscape from the older ones, as well as what gives it its circular form, is the fact that the fields are watered not by a ditch or system of dams and ditches leading from some lake or reservoir. Each field has its own central well. A motor, located at the wellhead, drives a perforated aluminum pipe on wheels, a pipe a quarter of a mile long, around the field. Water is dispensed in a uniform spray as the pipe moves at any speed between one revolution a week or one revolution an hour. Mixed with the water thus distributed is often a determined amount of chemical fertilizer, herbicide, or insecticide. Airborne infrared scanners record the ground temperature at any given time, as well as the rate of evaporation, and an appropriate irrigation schedule can be established. For these procedures to be effective and profitable, the precise composition of the soil and of the water has to be known, and the vagaries of the climate studied and taken into account. As for the crops themselves—corn or alfalfa or cotton or sorghum or wheat—genetic engineering is seeking to develop plants which will capture sunlight with greater efficiency, use less water, and at the same time produce more abundantly. Once the schedule of irrigation is programmed, a single experienced central pivot operator can take care of at least ten fields.

This computerization of irrigation farming is not only stimulating to read

about, it widens and deepens our perception of the new landscape by taking us below the surface, as it were; and the technological and financial infrastructure is precisely what should give us concern. The enormous investment in engineering, in equipment, in servicing, and maintaining each operation means that this kind of irrigation is at present well beyond the reach of the average landowning farmer. In his book on American agriculture, Walter Ebeling quotes a farm manager as saying that he had made a New Jersey investor in central pivot systems in Nebraska a millionaire.[1] And while this kind of sprinkler irrigation actually uses less water per acre than the traditional ditch irrigation, it has become so general in certain sections of the High Plains that it is only a matter of time before some wells run dry, and when that happens we will see round fields not of green but of a desolate gray.

Still, as air travelers, as amateur viewers of the landscape, our role is simply to look at the visible results of these projects and problems and to postpone the passing of ecological or social judgment until all the evidence is in. Americans are capable of seeing the dangers ahead and of trying to circumvent them. We can learn to breed and grow plants which use less water; we can also devise smaller and less expensive central pivot systems and other types of sprinklers. When tractors were introduced into American agriculture they were huge and costly and seemed to spell the doom of the small American farmer. Instead, they became small and inexpensive and versatile. A sustained interest in this landscape should eventually lead us to look for signs of change in the panorama below us. Already by looking closely, we can observe that the perfectly circular field of 130 acres of greenery has in many places begun to reach out and occupy some of the hitherto neglected corners which the rotating pipe could not reach. Eventually we will see square fields, and that, I think, from the spectator's point of view, will be a loss.

In the meantime we would do well to recall that newer definition of a landscape—an organization of man-made spaces—and with an artist's eye interpret what we see. Obviously we are looking down on what must be the most artificial, the most minutely planned and controlled agricultural landscape in America. But artificiality to a greater or less extent is part of every landscape, and what we should also note is that this kind of irrigation requires little or no modification of the topography. That in fact is why sprinkler irrigation is popular in the High Plains: the countryside is sufficiently rolling and uneven to make the digging of ditches and the watering of the surface a difficult if not an impossible task. The water, therefore, comes in the form of artificial rain and this rain, if moderate enough, sinks into the ground, no matter how uneven the surface. So these definitely artificial fields—artificial in form, artificial in content—merely lie on the surface and represent no permanent topographical change. Unlike the irrigated fields in the older landscape—bulldozed, leveled, sliced and scarred by ditches—these

round fields can be abandoned without leaving a trace, just as traditional fields eventually revert to second growth and wilderness. In time we will see this happen again.

Perhaps the most significant feature of this High Plains landscape is the extraordinary self-sufficiency, the autonomy and functional isolation of each of these innumerable green circles; like billiard balls, they barely touch their neighbors, and nothing except propinquity seems to relate them one to another. Each grows its own crop according to its own individual schedule, each depends for its survival not on a common (or communal) supply of water or on a common tradition of farming or even on a common weather pattern, but solely on its own individual supply coming from its own well. We are confronted with the realization that these are not fields in the accepted sense of the word; these are areas or spaces rigidly defined by an influence or power emanating from a central source. Such is the scientific use of the word *field,* but we must now use it in discussing a farm landscape: the central agent of course is the pump, or the flow of water it produces, and these are fields of energy, for once given visible form.

It is surely a development of some significance when an ancient and familiar word begins to shift in definition, for it suggests that many other commonly accepted features of the landscape are likewise undergoing transformation. It would be foolish to attach too much importance to the development of a new and perhaps short-lived type of irrigation landscape. At the same time, it would be more than foolish to discount the many changes which have taken place over the last generations. And these changes are not merely a matter of shape and scale in the landscape, evident in the mile after mile of identical discs of green, slipping by beneath us like items on an assembly line, nor even a matter of the invisible power of computers to change the microclimate and the growth of plants. The real change is in ourselves and how we see the world. Flight has given us new eyes, and we are using them to discover a new order of spaces, new landscapes wherever we look.

Concluding with Landscapes



Southeastern Utah. (Photo: author)

Often a disconcerting thought has come to me and given me pause. It is this: Whatever I may have fondly supposed, all that I have been writing and saying over the past years has in the last analysis dealt with a single topic—how to define (or redefine) the concept *landscape*. The *concept;* not landscape as phenomena, as environments; these I have been able to handle without much difficulty. What everyone likes to hear is that the landscape where they live is unique of its kind, worthy of the closest study, and so one has only to emphasize its *unique* characteristics to give full satisfaction. Yet an unforeseen complication has arisen. The greater the number of landscapes I explored, the more it seemed that they all had traits in common and that the essence of each was not its uniqueness but its similarity to others. It occurred to me that there might be such a thing as a prototypal landscape, or more precisely landscape as a primordial idea, of which all these visible landscapes were merely so many imperfect manifestations. It then became a question of defining that idea or concept, after which the defining of the individual landscape would be plain sailing.

I cannot say that many others in the field of environmental studies have shared this perplexity of mine—a perplexity which any medieval monk could have disposed of in short order. I have been given to understand that the problem had been more than adequately handled by geographers and anthropologists, and that it would be far better if I were concerned with the landscape itself—particularly the contemporary American landscape, much in need of criticism and reform. That may well have been good advice. Yet when we use a word carelessly (as we now use the word *landscape*) we are likely to get into trouble; and it is always prudent to know what we are talking about.

I have mentioned more than once how unsatisfactory we all find the current dictionary definition of the word: "A view or vista of scenery on the land, or a painting depicting such a scene." The formula dates back more than three hundred years. But since then we have learned to see a landscape as something more than beautiful scenery. We have learned that it can be designed and created from scratch, that it can grow old and fall into decay. We have ceased to think of it as remote from our daily lives, and indeed we now believe that to be part of a landscape, to derive our identity from it is an essential precondition of our being-in-the-world, in the most solemn meaning of the phrase. It is this greatly expanded significance of landscape that makes a new definition so necessary now.

In time we will doubtless formulate one. What we have recently come up with, in default of help from the dictionary, is something admittedly makeshift and incomplete. By rejecting the strictly esthetic or phenomenological approach—landscape as an isolated phenomenon stripped of origins and functions, unrelated to existence—we are able to discuss it in mundane terms, and it is not uncommon to hear a landscape referred to as the expression in terms of space of a given social order, a kind of two-dimensional language

with its own grammar and its own logic. The simile may lack precision; just the same, those who use it find it full of useful suggestions. Like a language, a landscape will have obscure and undecipherable origins, like a language it is the slow creation of all elements in society. It grows according to its own laws, rejecting or accepting neologisms as it sees fit, clinging to obsolescent forms, inventing new ones. A landscape, like a language, is the field of perpetual conflict and compromise between what is established by authority and what the vernacular insists upon preferring. Like the grammarian or the lexicographer, the planner, the reformer has to take a stand, and it is usually on the side of what is rational and correct, on the side of the intellectual establishment. That is as it should be. We are familiar enough with the tyranny a too highly structured language or a landscape too carefully planned can exert, but there is something to be said for rules, however arbitrary. Just as a language without established standards of elegance and clarity and respect for tradition can thwart the best of minds, a landscape left to itself without long-range goals, without structure, without law, though it may call itself a paradise, ends by frustrating any search for social or moral order.

The comparison can be carried just so far, but in the case of both language and landscape, growth and preservation and beauty is finally, I think, a matter of history and how we deal with it. Whatever definition of landscape we finally reach, to be serviceable it will have to take into account the ceaseless interaction between the ephemeral, the mobile, the vernacular on the one hand, and the authority of legally established, premeditated permanent forms on the other.

It may be that I am here on the track of that elusive landscape concept: the ideal landscape defined not as a static utopia dedicated to ecological or social or religious principles, but as an environment where permanence and change have struck a balance. Few landscapes have achieved this and fewer still have managed to maintain it for any length of time. But all of them, it seems to me, have sought it; all of them in one manner or another, that is to say, have acknowledged the existence of landscape as idea. The world being what it is, it is far easier to find examples of imbalance than of landscape balance. The two examples of the former I offer are worth studying not merely for their cautionary value—for one shows the perils of mobility, the other the perils which come with too great a regard for *position* in the landscape—but also because they are both related, though indirectly, to our own American landscape and its future.

I have elsewhere explained the original meaning of the word *landscape,* so it is enough to say that it meant a collection, a "sheaf" of lands, presumably interrelated and part of a system. A land was a defined piece of ground, and we can assume that in the medieval world it was most often used to indicate a patch of plowed or cultivated ground, that being the most valuable kind. Landscape therefore must have been a word much used by villagers and

peasants and farmhands; it described their own small world. But how much was it used by other elements in society? It rarely occurs in legal documents of the period. The Domesday Book, a remarkable inventory of land holdings compiled by order of William the Conqueror in the eleventh century, was, to be sure, written in Latin, but no translation ever mentioned landscape, and indeed the word itself seems to have fallen into disuse. Two centuries after the conquest a new term, imported from France, though of Latin origin, took its place. *Country* or *countryside* came to indicate a much more extensive, though less precisely defined area: the territory of a community of people all speaking the same dialect, all engaged in the same kind of farming, all subjects of the same local lord, all conscious of having customs and traditions of their own and of possessing certain ancient rights and privileges. It was not until modern times that the word *country* came to indicate *nation*.

It is here, in the usage of the two words *landscape* and *country,* that we are confronted with the distinction between the vernacular and the aristocratic or political concepts of space. In the view of the noblemen and clergy, of the larger landowners, *landscape* was merely a vernacular or peasant term describing a cluster of small, temporary, crudely measured spaces which frequently changed hands and even changed in shape and size. It was, in fact, a fragment of a larger feudal estate, a right or series of rights granted to its occupants but ultimately the property of the lord or of the crown. It was a term current only in small villages. The aristocratic concept of space was entirely different. The estate of a nobleman or of a bishop, the barony or domain of the knight, the forest of the king, not to mention his kingdom, all had a definite, almost sacred origin, their boundaries vouched for by treaty or charter. Those who held them not only had the right to administer justice, but to bequeath them to their descendants. Aristocratic space, in the medieval world, was thus permanent and relatively autonomous. It was the creation of political or legal decisions.

Although the two kinds of space were intermingled, the difference between the two ways of seeing the world and of organizing space was profound, and insofar as we are exploring the early usage of the word *landscape* it is the *vernacular* landscape which concerns us. The current tendency to associate the word *vernacular* with a local form of speech and a local form of art and decoration entitles us to use the word to describe other aspects of local culture. The word derives from the Latin *verna,* meaning a slave born in the house of his or her master, and by extension in Classical times it meant a native, one whose existence was confined to a village or estate and who was devoted to routine work. A vernacular culture would imply a way of life ruled by tradition and custom, entirely remote from the larger world of politics and law; a way of life where identity derived not from permanent possession of land but from membership in a group or super-family.

It follows, I think, that there can be such a thing as a vernacular landscape:

one where evidences of a political organization of space are largely or entirely absent. I have already mentioned several features of the political landscape: the visibility and sanctity of boundaries, the importance of monuments and of centrifugal highways, the close relationship between status and enclosed space. By *political* I mean those spaces and structures designed to impose or preserve a unity and order on the land, or in keeping with a long-range, large-scale plan. Under that heading we should include such modern features as the interstate highway, the hydroelectric dam, the airport and power transmission lines, whether we happen to care for them or not.

A vernacular landscape reveals a distinct way of defining and handling time and space. In the United States there is a series of vernacular landscapes of a particularly pure type in the Pueblo Indian communities of the Southwest, and whenever we see one we are likely to find it confusing and all but impossible to interpret in our conventional European–American terms. The medieval landscape is scarcely easier to understand, even though in the course of centuries it gradually acquired several political components: castles, manors, king's highways, and chartered cities. These are what enable us to see its evolution. Yet underneath those symbols of permanent political power there lay a vernacular landscape—or rather thousands of small and impoverished vernacular landscapes, organizing and using spaces in their traditional way and living in communities governed by custom, held together by personal relationships. We learn something about them by investigating the topographical and technological and social factors which determined their economy and their way of life, but in the long run I suspect no landscape, vernacular or otherwise, can be comprehended unless we perceive it as an organization of space; unless we ask ourselves who owns or uses the spaces, how they were created and how they change. Often it is the legal aspects of the landscape that give us the clearest insight, especially into the relationship between the peasant or villager and the piece of land he works.

"It is very rare, during the whole of the feudal era," Marc Bloch remarks,

> for anyone to speak of ownership, either of an estate or an office. . . . [T]he word ownership as applied to landed property would have been almost meaningless . . . for nearly all land and a great many human beings were burdened at this time with a multiplicity of obligations differing in their nature, but all apparently of equal merit. None implied the fixed proprietary exclusiveness which belonged to the concept of ownership in Roman law. The tenant who—from father to son, as a rule—ploughs the land and gathers in the crop; his immediate lord to whom he pays dues and who, in certain circumstances, can resume possession of the land; the lord of the lord, and so on, right up the feudal ladder—how many persons there are who can say, each with as much justification as the other "that is my field!"[1]

Spaces in this vernacular landscape thus indicate personal relationships, and they indicate in no less complicated manner the involved and often

conflicting traditions of the community: who controls the vast number of "waste spaces"—some as extensive as a whole moor or marsh, others no larger than the margin of a road or a lane. Is the road itself a waste? Given a new use, a space changes its name: a "land" grown to grass becomes a "ley"; waste, preempted by the crown, becomes a royal forest with its own set of laws. Maitland, the legal historian, endeavoring to make legal sense of the landscape of medieval Cambridge, reminds us of its hopeless complexity and bids us "think of the grantor [King John] and his royal rights, of the grantees and their complex interests, of the strips in the fields and the odds and ends of sward, of the green commons of the town, of the house covered nucleus . . . of the patchwork of fiefs, the network of rents"[2]—and from this confusion we are somehow to deduce a coherent spatial pattern.

At the present state of our studies of the vernacular landscape as a type all that we can say is that its spaces are usually small, irregular in shape, subject to rapid change in use, in ownership, in dimensions; that the houses, even the villages themselves, grow, shrink, change morphology, change location; that there is always a vast amount of "common land"—waste, pasturage, forest, areas where natural resources are exploited in a piecemeal manner; that its roads are little more than paths and lanes, never maintained and rarely permanent; finally that the vernacular landscape is a scattering of hamlets and clusters of fields, islands in a sea of waste or wilderness changing from generation to generation, leaving no monuments, only abandonment or signs of renewal.

Mobility and change are the key to the vernacular landscape, but of an involuntary, reluctant sort; not the expression of restlessness and search for improvement but an unending patient adjustment to circumstances. Far too often these are the arbitrary decisions of those in power, but natural conditions play their part and so do ignorance and a blind loyalty to local ways, and so does the absence of long-range objectives: the absence of what we would call a sense of future history. A vernacular landscape, both in the Southwest and in medieval Europe, is an impressive display of devotion to common customs and of an inexhaustible ingenuity in finding short-term solutions.

At the same time we cannot overlook what to us is the cultural poverty of such a landscape, its lack of any purposeful continuity. It thinks not of history but of legends and myths. Well into the Renaissance and even later, the inhabitants of vernacular landscapes in Europe still half-believed in heathen divinities, adorned their houses with heathen symbols, and observed heathen rites and holidays. Even historical figures, like Charlemagne or Barbarossa, historical events like the Crusades or the actual settlement of a town or city, were transformed into fairy tales. They lived in a landscape of ancient villages, ruined castles, churches built on the site of temples, yet the only monuments they recognized were miraculous springs, magic rocks, and trees, the only event they understood was the sound of Odin with his pack of hounds

rushing through the forest by night. A landscape without visible signs of political history is a landscape without memory or forethought. We are inclined in America to think that the value of monuments is simply to remind us of origins. They are much more valuable as reminders of long-range, collective purpose, of goals and objectives and principles. As such even the least sightly of monuments gives a landscape beauty and dignity and keeps the collective memory alive.

Let us call that early medieval landscape Landscape One. There is another landscape (which we may call Landscape Two), which began to take shape in the latter part of the fifteenth century and which we can associate with the Renaissance; and since we are giving them names, let us identify a Landscape Three, which we can see in certain aspects of contemporary America.

I am tempted to think that Landscape Three is already beginning to show some of the characteristics of Landscape One, but before I offer evidence let me say something about Landscape Two, which was in many ways the reverse of Landscape One. We are in fact very familiar with Landscape Two. Artists and architects and landscape designers spend much time studying it, and they copy it in their professional work; and all of us who write about it travel to Europe to see it at firsthand. So I merely mention the ways in which it differs from Landscape One. Its spaces, rural and urban, are clearly and permanently defined and made visible by walls and hedges or zones of open greenery or lawn. They are designed to be self-contained and shapely and beautiful. Landscape Two sets great score on visibility; that is why we have that seventeenth-century definition of landscape as "a vista or view of scenery of the land"—landscape as a work of art, as a kind of supergarden. Unlike Landscape One, which mixed all kinds of uses and spaces together, Landscape Two insists on spaces which are homogenous and devoted to a single purpose. It makes a distinction between city and country, between forest and field, between public and private, rich and poor, work and play; it prefers the linear frontier between nations rather than the medieval patchwork of intermingled territories. As for the distinction between mobility and immobility, it clearly believes that whatever is temporary or short-lived or movable is not to be encouraged.

But the essential characteristic of Landscape Two is its belief in the sanctity of *place*. It is place, permanent position both in the social and topographical sense, that gives us our identity. The function of space according to this belief is to make us visible, allow us to put down roots and become members of society. Land in Landscape One meant being a member of a working community; it was a temporary symbol of relationships. In Landscape Two land means property and permanence and power.

Landscape Two started to evolve at a time in European history when the old customary farm community with its disposable parcels of land and its

confusion of rights and obligations was being abandoned in favor of the individual ownership and operation of farms: private holdings composed of single-purpose permanent fields with the homestead of the owner in the center of the property. This was a time when men were discovering the natural environment and its many variations in climate and soil and topography, and when the challenge to agriculture was to define all varieties of land and put them to their appropriate use. It was in consequence a time when the forest was discovered as a distinct environment, with distinct economic and ecological characteristics; an environment worth preserving and improving.

There is little new to be said about the beauty and order of Landscape Two. It remains to this day the most successful landscape, esthetically speaking, that there has ever been in the Western world, one which we will always try to imitate when we want to produce landscapes for delight and inspiration. Americans have a special reason for admiring it, for it is here in the United States that we see the largest and most impressive example of neoclassic spatial organization. Our national grid system, devised by the Founding Fathers, represents the last attempt to produce a Classical political landscape, one based on the notion that certain spaces—notably the square and the rectangle—were inherently beautiful and therefore suited to the creation of a just society. I is, to be sure, a landscape with few dramatic beauties and much monotony, but it is a landscape which conforms to Winckelmann's definition of Classical perfection: one of noble simplicity and quiet grandeur.

What we enjoy about the early-nineteenth-century American landscape is the ease with which it can be read and interpreted. The farm stands in the midst of its fields and clearly reveals its degree of prosperity and contentment. Each church has a white steeple, each public square has a monument, each field its fence, each straight road its destination. It is a landscape of rectangular fields, green woodlands, white houses, and red brick towns. It is like a luminous painting: vivid, carefully composed, appealing to the emotions, and reassuringly stable.

Yet it did not last for long: scarcely a half century, and a number of reasons can be given for its rapid decay: the coming of the railroad, the opening up of newer land further West, the invention of the balloon frame and of horse-drawn farm equipment, the growth of manufacturing in the East, the influx of settlers from Europe—all these developments affected the spatial organization of Landscape Two in America and in a few decades made it obsolete. Yet I cannot help feeling that even from the start Landscape Two was not entirely suited to us. It never produced those politically active farm communities that Jefferson and his colleagues dreamt of, never really persuaded us to put down roots and stay put in one place. Instead of being a blueprint for the ideal Classical democratic social order, the grid system became simply an easy and effective way of dividing up the land and of encouraging the settlement of the Midwest. The question which we will eventually have to confront is whether

Landscape Two ever belonged in the English-speaking New World. (I say *English-speaking* advisedly, because it *did* take hold in Latin America.)

The settlement of Anglo-Americans can best be understood as a belated episode in the history of Landscape One: a last titanic wave of mobility, of immigrants leaving the vanishing vernacular landscape of rural England. Once settled here, the predominantly young, blue-collar population produced a colonial version of Landscape One—but lacking in one important traditional feature: the farm village. New England tried to produce it, the authorities in London tried to produce it in Virginia, but new ways of farming, new kinds of land ownership, and a new kind of freedom frustrated every attempt, and by the time of the Revolution even in New England the farm village was out of date. What survived of that early colonial vernacular culture was its mobility, its adaptability, its preference for the transitory, the ephemeral: the short-lived log cabins, the brief exploitation of the environment; the ad hoc community of the frontier and the trading post, even while the grid of Landscape Two stood waiting for Jefferson's Classical farm villages to appear.

It would be wrong to imply that modern America is entirely the product of that vernacular culture, or that we do not possess a vast and rich landscape, urban as well as rural, dedicated to stability and history and established landscape values. My concern is that these two landscapes do not always recognize what each has to offer to the other and that Landscape Three may fail to achieve a balance between them. I do not believe that the Establishment—political, intellectual, artistic—is aware of the vitality and extent of that vernacular element, and I do not believe that we recognize the danger of having two distinct sublandscapes, one dedicated to stability and place, the other dedicated to mobility. Such was the case in Landscape One. Our vernacular landscape has unparalleled vitality and diversity, but it resembles Landscape One in its detachment from formal space, its indifference to history, and its essentially utilitarian, conscienceless use of the environment. We cannot say that we are returning to the Dark Ages, but the similarity between Landscape Three and Landscape One is based on an important circumstance: both lack the humanist tradition of the Renaissance. Both are ignorant of Landscape Two and what it stood for.

As I travel about the country, I am often bewildered by the proliferation of spaces and the uses of spaces that had no counterpart in the traditional landscape: parking lots, landing fields, shopping centers, trailer courts, high-rise condominiums, wildlife shelters, Disneyland. I am bewildered by our casual use of space: churches used as discotheques, dwellings used as churches, downtown streets used for jogging, empty lots in crowded cities, industrial plants in the open country, cemeteries used for archery practice, Easter sunrise services in a football stadium. I am confused by the temporary spaces

I see: the drive-in, fast-food establishments that are torn down after a year, the fields planted to corn and then to soya beans and then subdivided; the trailer communities that vanish when vacation time is over, the tropical gardens in shopping malls that are replaced each season; motels abandoned when the highway moves. Because of my age my first reaction to these new spaces is dismay; they are not the kind of spaces I was accustomed to in the Landscape Two of my youth. But my second and (I hope) more tolerant reaction is that all this is part of our culture, that it can be treated with respect and that here is a new and challenging field of environmental design.

I would like to think that in the future the profession of landscape architecture will expand beyond its present confines (established by Landscape Two) and involve itself in making mobility orderly and beautiful. This would mean knowing a great deal about land, its uses, its values, and the political and economic and cultural forces affecting its distribution. The environmental designer should be concerned with the spatial changes taking place. It is precisely in the field of land use and community planning that a trained imagination, an awareness of environment and habitat can be of the greatest value. What has been done in the way of producing new landscapes, new wilderness areas, farms and factories and cities in Holland and Israel could serve as a model. Environmental design is not simply a matter of protecting nature as it is, but of creating a new nature, a new beauty. It is finally a matter of defining landscape in a way that includes both the mobility of the vernacular and the political infrastructure of a stable social order.

In matters having to do with the natural environment we are most of us children of Landscape Two. From that parent we have learned not only to study the world around us but also to lavish care upon it and bring it to a state of lasting perfection. It was Landscape Two that taught us that the contemplation of nature can be a kind of revelation of the invisible world, and of ourselves.

But it was also Landscape Two that impressed upon us the notion that there can be only *one* kind of landscape: a landscape identified with a very static, very conservative social order, and that there can be only one true philosophy of nature: that of Landscape Two.

That first heritage of love and wonder is still with us, stronger perhaps than ever. It is that other heritage, that clinging to obsolete forms and attitudes, that threatens the emergence of a truly balanced Landscape Three. We no longer live in the country, we no longer farm, we no longer derive our identity from possession of land. Like the harassed peasant of Landscape One, though to a far greater degree, we derive our identity from our relationship with other people, and when we talk about the importance of *place,* the necessity of belonging to a *place,* let us be clear that in Landscape Three place means the people in it, not simply the natural environment. For political and economic reasons Landscape Two greatly exaggerated the importance of

belonging to a community. But the agricultural community was what was meant, the tightly organized hierarchy of landowners and masters and workers. Not every applicant was admitted, and the conditions attached to membership were strict and arbitrary; final acceptance was slow in coming. In Landscape Three the reverse is the case, and the ease with which a stranger can be assimilated, the speed with which a new community can come into being are both extraordinary phenomena. It may not be entirely accurate to say (as a developer once said to me) that "people follow plumbing," meaning that utilities are the infrastructure of any residential community. It is nevertheless true that we have abandoned the old political procedures of creating places. The forming of a new community now calls for little more than the gregarious impulse of a dozen families attracted by certain elementary public services. This is the kind of new community that we are seeing all over America: at remote construction sites, in recreation areas, in trailer courts, in the shanty towns of wetbacks and migrant workers; the emergence of what we may call vernacular communities—without political status, without plan, ruled by informal local custom, often ingenious adaptations to an unlikely site and makeshift materials, destined to last no more than a year or two, and working as well as most communities do. They would be better and last longer if they were properly designed and serviced. They could acquire dignity if the political landscape made a gesture of recognition. Yet very little is needed to give those new communities a true identity: a reminder, a symbol of permanence to indicate that they too have a history ahead of them.

One reason for paying more attention to this aspect of Landscape Three is that these settlements will in time serve as nuclei for small-scale landscapes. For that is always how landscapes have been formed; not only by topography and political decisions, but by the indigenous organization and development of spaces to serve the needs of the focal community: gainful employment, recreation, social contacts, contacts with nature, contacts with the alien world. In one form or another, these are the ends which all landscapes serve, and that is why they are all fundamentally versions of the primal *idea* of landscape.

My search for a definition has led me back to that old Anglo-Saxon meaning: landscape is not scenery, it is not a political unit; it is really no more than a collection, a system of man-made spaces on the surface of the earth. Whatever its shape or size it is *never* simply a natural space, a feature of the natural environment; it is *always* artificial, always synthetic, always subject to sudden or unpredictable change. We create them and need them because every landscape is the place where we establish our own human organization of space and time. It is where the slow, natural processes of growth and maturity and decay are deliberately set aside and history is substituted. A landscape is where we speed up or retard or divert the cosmic program and impose our own. "By conquering nature," Mircea Eliade writes, "man can

become Nature's rival without being the slave of time. . . . Science and industry proclaim that man can achieve things better and faster than nature if he, by means of his intelligence, succeeds in penetrating to her secrets."[3]

When we see how we have succeeded in imposing our own rhythm on nature in the agricultural landscape, how we have altered the life cycle of plants and animals and even transposed the seasons, we become aware of how dangerous a role we have assumed, and there are many who say that the salvation of Landscape Three depends on our relinquishing this power to alter the flow of time and on our returning to a more natural order. But the new ordering of time should affect not only nature, it should affect ourselves. It promises us a new kind of history, a new, more responsive social order, and ultimately a new landscape.